BHARATVERSE

SHALINI

CHAPTER 1
FOUR SECONDS

MUMBAI SECTOR OFFICE
03:00 AM

She did not go home.

At three in the morning Commander Shalini Bose sat alone in the comm room of the Mumbai sector office with the lights off and a mug of tea going cold at her elbow, and she played the recording twice.

In nine years she had never played one twice.

A recording was a fact, and facts did not improve with repetition.

She had told every analyst who ever worked for her: if you need to hear it again, you did not listen the first time.

She listened to all of it anyway.

The fire. The vacuum strikes. Shekhawat, polite to the end, saying orders to a man who had just declined to kill him.

Her own voice, flat and even.

"Major.
Dialogue has failed.
The brief has a lever.
Use it."

Then one word in a quiet voice, and the sound of a building beginning to breathe.

"Priya."

Then, near the end.

"Ma'am. Who is Priya Mehta?"

And a silence on the channel, four seconds long.

That silence had been hers.

She had held her thumb over the key and said nothing and heard him breathe, and she had counted. She did not know why.

She counted again now.

AUDIO ANALYSIS - FIELD RECORDING 02:14:00 – 02:14:12

NULL

AUDIO (FIELD)

PRESSURE TRACE (DR. KRISHNAMURTHY)

BUILDING VIBRATION

AMBIENT NOISE

4.00 s

On the second pass she listened for what she had missed.

At 02:14:07, the pressure trace from Dr. Krishnamurthy's sensor van went flat for four seconds.

Not a gap. A null.

Every noise in the field, the fire, the roof, the building flexing like a lung, dropped to nothing inside a perfect sphere centred on the man who had just come apart.

Then the sphere closed, and he stood up.

Four seconds.
She noticed it was a number that kept turning up.

She had seen that shape once before.

2001 ?
2011 ?
2023 ?
2027 ?

02:14:07
4.00
4.00

She wrote nothing down.

She took the small key that hung inside her collar

and unlocked the bottom drawer of her desk.

BHARATVERSE

SHALINI

CHAPTER 2 — THE DRAWER

The file was thin, which was the point.

Three items. She laid them out on the desk and squared the edges, as she always did, because squaring edges kept her hands busy.

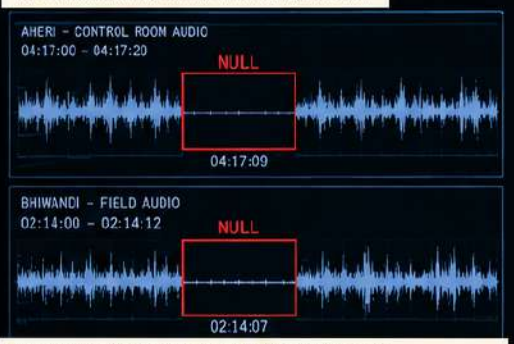
The first was a key-card log from the Aheri facility.

AHERI RESEARCH FACILITY — ACCESS LOG

DATE	TIME	LOCATION	CARD ID	USER
15-03	04:17:22	MAIN LAB	A7-1189	DR. R. K.
15-03	04:17:40	SERVICE DUCT	D9-3176	DEEPAK SABNIS
15-03	04:18:03	SERVICE DUCT	D9-3176	DEEPAK SABNIS

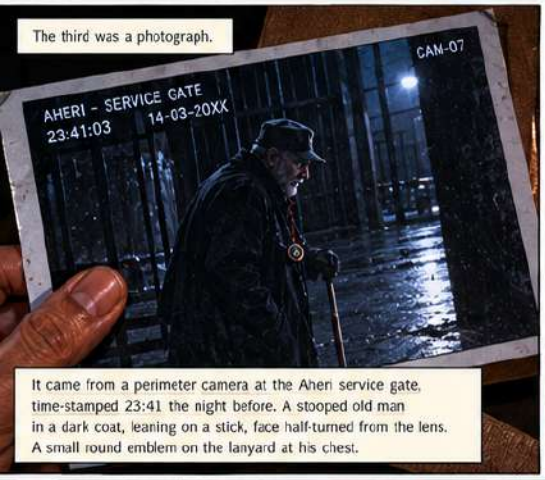
A service duct door, opened from inside at 04:17:40 by a card issued to Deepak Sabnis, the project coordinator, who had since ceased to exist.

The second was a strip of control-room microphone trace.



At 04:17:09, seconds after the wave, a pocket of absolute silence a metre across, centred on the position of the junior consultant. She laid the new graph from Bhiwandi beside it. The curves matched to the decimal.

The third was a photograph.



It came from a perimeter camera at the Aheri service gate, time-stamped 23:41 the night before. A stooped old man in a dark coat, leaning on a stick, face half-turned from the lens. A small round emblem on the lanyard at his chest.

She had known that stoop for twenty-two years.



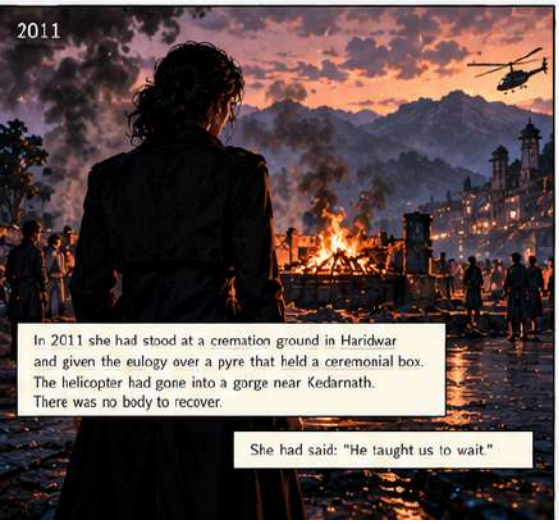
2004

Dr. Anand Kulkarni had interviewed her in 2004 in an office with one chair and a wood stove.



She had been twenty-nine, IPS, impatient. He had read her file for a long time. She had waited for him ever since.

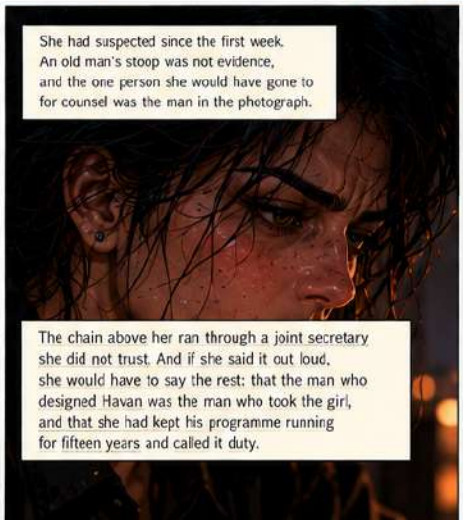
2011



In 2011 she had stood at a cremation ground in Haridwar and given the eulogy over a pyre that held a ceremonial box. The helicopter had gone into a gorge near Kedarnath. There was no body to recover.

She had said: "He taught us to wait."

She had suspected since the first week. An old man's stoop was not evidence, and the one person she would have gone to for counsel was the man in the photograph.



The chain above her ran through a joint secretary she did not trust. And if she said it out loud, she would have to say the rest: that the man who designed Havan was the man who took the girl, and that she had kept his programme running for fifteen years and called it duty.



She put the photograph face down and sat in the dark for a long time.



BHARATVERSE

SHALINI

CHAPTER 3
THE WORD

The Joint Secretary rang at ten past six.

06:10 AM
MUMBAI SECTOR OFFICE

Suhas Iyer's voice was pleasant, tired, and entirely civil, the voice of a man who had never in his life had to raise it.

Commander.
I hear there was some excitement in Bhiwandi.

SUHAS IYER
Joint Secretary
Ministry of Home Affairs

A godown fire, Joint Secretary. Eleven workers, all recovered. Subject V was on site. Major Shekhawat made contact, and Subject V declined the offer. No public exposure beyond a few phone clips.

Good, good.

And I gather the lever you used on the Mehta boy didn't take.

She did not move.

Yes, Joint Secretary. It failed.

Good, good.

After he hung up, she put the receiver down very gently and sat with her hands flat on the desk.

The word **lever** had been spoken in exactly one place: her own mouth, on a closed channel to a single earpiece in a burning building.

It had appeared in no report.

And she had never once, in any document that left her desk, written the boy's name. Subject V. Always.

For months. She had kept it out of every channel because a name travels, and a subject without a name can only be talked about in the abstract.

OPERATION REPORT - FIELD CONTACT
SUBJECT: V
LOCATION: BHIWANDI (IND)
ASSET: MAJOR A. SHEKHAWAT
OUTCOME: SUBJECT DECLINED

Suhas Iyer had said **Mehta**.

Either her comm channel was open, or the Joint Secretary was reading someone else's mail.

She found she could not decide which was worse.

She decided to act as if both were true.

She took out a pad and a pencil, the first she had used in six years, and wrote three lines in her small square hand.

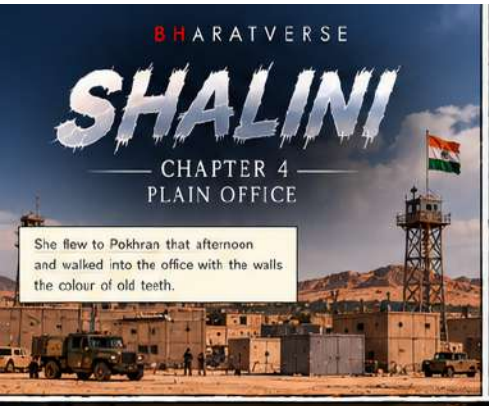
1. CHANNELS COMPROMISED.
2. JOHINT NOT CLEAN.
3. IN PERSON ONLY.

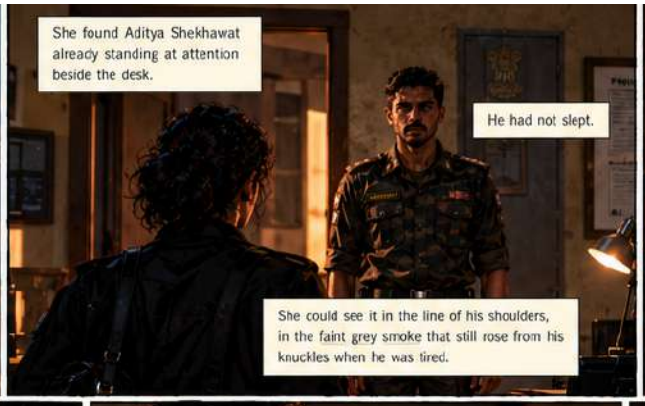
No more voice.
No more encrypted files.
Paper, hand-delivered, one reader.

She tore the page into strips, folded them into her pocket,

and went to find the one reader she was fairly sure of.

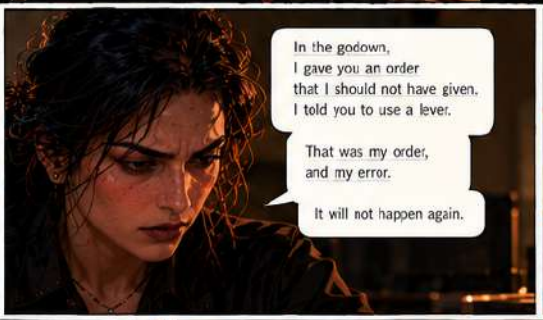
गृह मंत्रालय
MINISTRY OF HOME AFFAIRS


BHARATVERSE
SHALINI
CHAPTER 4
PLAIN OFFICE
She flew to Pokhran that afternoon and walked into the office with the walls the colour of old teeth.


She found Aditya Shekhawat already standing at attention beside the desk.
He had not slept.
She could see it in the line of his shoulders, in the faint grey smoke that still rose from his knuckles when he was tired.


He looked, she thought, like a very well-made instrument that had begun to hear itself.
POKHRAN


Sit, Major.
He did. He did not ask the question. She noticed that, and noticed the effort it cost him.

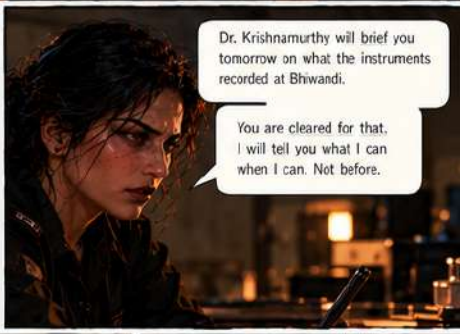

In the godown, I gave you an order that I should not have given. I told you to use a lever.
That was my order, and my error.
It will not happen again.


Ma'am. Who is Priya Mehta?


She did not answer aloud. She pushed a sheet of paper across the desk, and on it, in pencil, in five words:
She is alive. Say nothing.


He read it twice. His face did not change, but the paper began, very slightly, to curl at the corners.


He turned the sheet over, held it up between two fingers, and let it burn clean to ash in the air above the desk.
Nothing was left.


Dr. Krishnamurthy will brief you tomorrow on what the instruments recorded at Bhiwandi.
You are cleared for that. I will tell you what I can when I can. Not before.


Yes, ma'am.

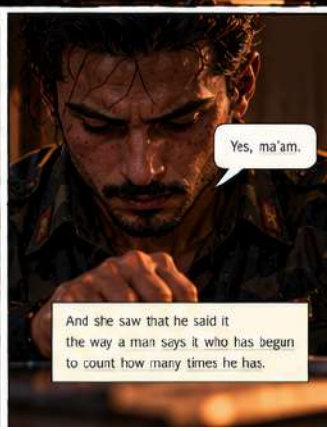

Do you have anything to say, Major?


I didn't need it, ma'am. The lever. I could have taken him without it.


I know.


The water protocol stays?


The water protocol stays.


Yes, ma'am.
And she saw that he said it the way a man says it who has begun to count how many times he has.

BHARATVERSE

SHALINI

CHAPTER 5
FIVE DOTS

By evening the reports had stacked up on her desk like weather.

INDIAN COAST GUARD
SITUATION LOG

REF: CG-MHB-2706
DATE: 14-03-20XX

DATE: 05:40 hrs

LOCATION: 4 km off Mahabalipuram, Chennai (TN)

Patrol boat observed two persons in what appeared to be combat above the sea. One apparently airborne. The sea itself was behaving as if it were fighting back. A trawler without lights was seen leaving the area. No arrests.



A coast guard log from Chennai, filed in the stilted prose of men who had not been told what they were looking at.

NARCOTICS CONTROL BUREAU
INTELLIGENCE DOSSIER

FILE: 0441-C
STATUS: ACTIVE

SHAIKH, ZARA

FILE NO.: 0441-C

CASES: Narcotics trafficking (Convicted)
Assault on a coast guard officer (Pending)

STATUS: Currently wanted. Absconding.



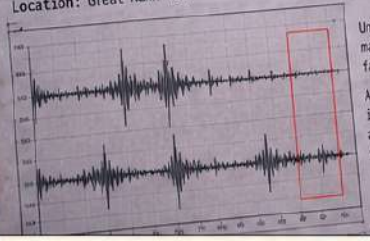
A cross-reference from the Narcotics Control Bureau, requested weeks ago and only now returned, for a woman whose name she had been waiting to learn.

NATIONAL CENTRE FOR SEISMOLOGY
REGIONAL BULLETIN

REF: NCS-WR-3187
DATE: 14-03-20XX

SEISMIC ACTIVITY - KACHCHH REGION

Location: Great Rann near Khavda (Gujarat)



Unusual seismic swarm matching no known fault line.

Activity stopped twice in under 90 seconds, as if someone had told it to.

A seismic bulletin from the National Centre, flagged by her own western sector analysts.



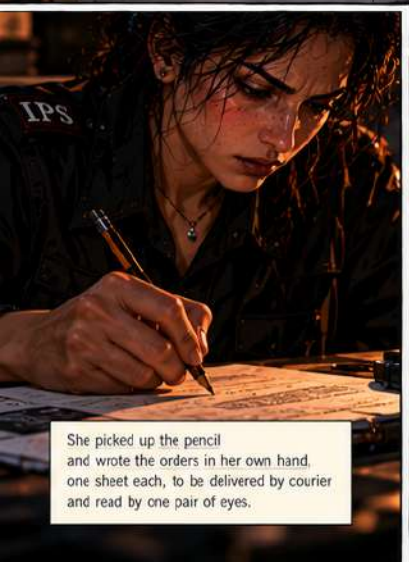
Four dots.
And somewhere above the northern edge of the map, a fifth she could not place.

They were being drawn together.

She stood looking at them for a long time.

She did not know by what, but she knew the shape of it,

as she knew the shape of an approaching storm from a change in the air.



She picked up the pencil and wrote the orders in her own hand, one sheet each, to be delivered by courier and read by one pair of eyes.

1. For Subject V

Subject V is no longer a containment priority.

Observation only.

No Division unit will engage.

2. Khavda

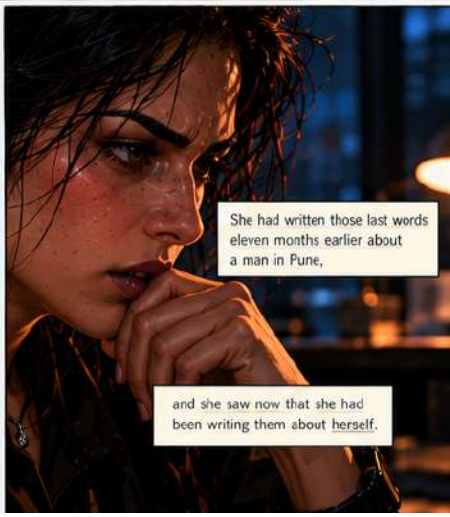
Khavda.
Observation only.

No uniforms, no approach.
A tripod and a tea stall.

Premature contact risks flight response.

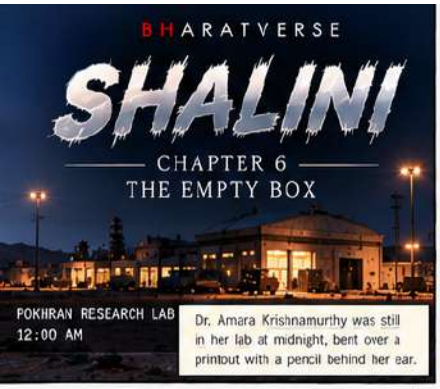
3. Chennai Coast

Chennai coast.
Log, do not act.

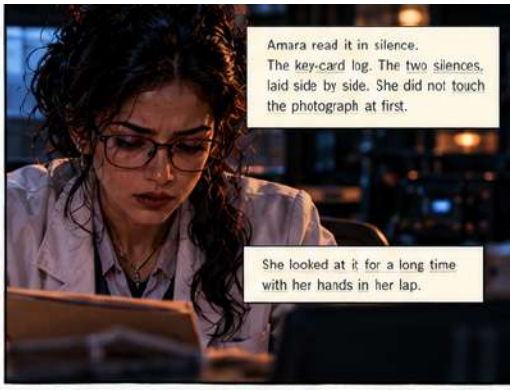


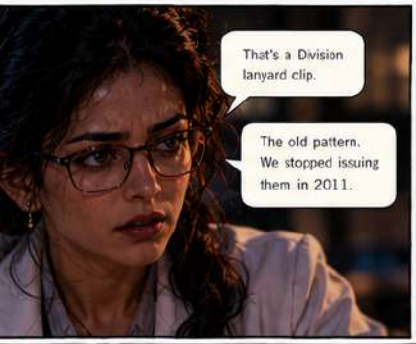
She had written those last words eleven months earlier about a man in Pune,

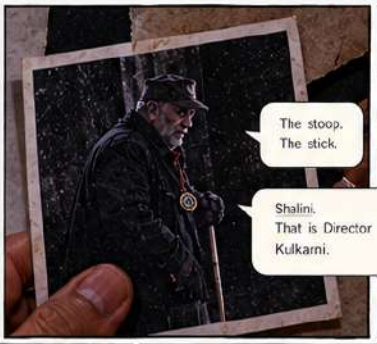
and she saw now that she had been writing them about herself.


BHARATVERSE
SHALINI
CHAPTER 6
THE EMPTY BOX
POKHRAN RESEARCH LAB
12:00 AM
Dr. Amara Krishnamurthy was still in her lab at midnight, bent over a printout with a pencil behind her ear.


You've decided something.
I've decided to stop waiting.
Read it.
Tell me I am wrong.

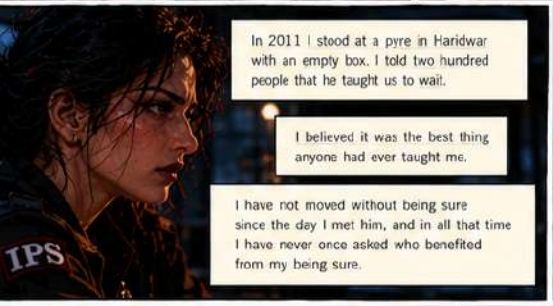

Amara read it in silence. The key-card log. The two silences, laid side by side. She did not touch the photograph at first.
She looked at it for a long time with her hands in her lap.


That's a Division lanyard clip.
The old pattern. We stopped issuing them in 2011.


The stoop. The stick.
Shalini. That is Director Kulkarni.

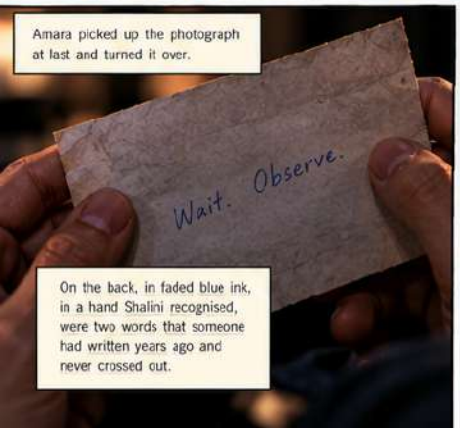

He died in 2011.
No body was recovered.
No.


You've known since Aheri.
I've suspected since Aheri. I have known since last night.
What changed last night?
Four seconds.


In 2011 I stood at a pyre in Haridwar with an empty box. I told two hundred people that he taught us to wait.
I believed it was the best thing anyone had ever taught me.
I have not moved without being sure since the day I met him, and in all that time I have never once asked who benefited from my being sure.
IPS

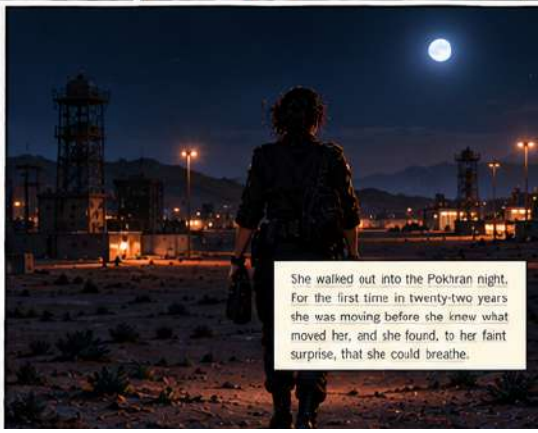

What do you want me to do?
Find out where the Foundation's money goes. Find out who in the ministry reads Division mail. Find out what he built, and where, and how many he has.
And do not tell the Joint Secretary. Do not tell anyone. Not Shekhawat. Not yet.


He's going to ask.
I know.


Amara picked up the photograph at last and turned it over.
Wait. Observe.
On the back, in faded blue ink, in a hand Shalini recognised, were two words that someone had written years ago and never crossed out.


Then we're late.


Yes, said Shalini Bose. For the first time in my career. I would very much like to be.


She walked out into the Pokhran night. For the first time in twenty-two years she was moving before she knew what moved her, and she found, to her faint surprise, that she could breathe.